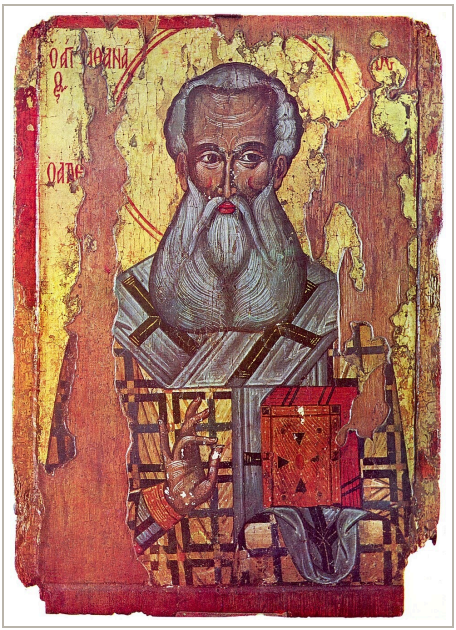
Monday, November 9, 2026

St. Athanasius

Bishop and Doctor of the Church · Feast, May 2



Saint Athanasius of Alexandria, Icon, Sozopol, Bulgaria, 17th century[1]

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1. Icon of Saint Athanasius of Alexandria, Sozopol, Bulgaria, 17th century; Wikimedia Commons.

✠ The Essentials

- **Origin:** Alexandria, Egypt.[2]
- **Born:** c. 296–298.[3]
- **Died:** May 2, 373, at Alexandria, peacefully in his own bed, surrounded by his clergy.[4]
- **Feast:** May 2, the anniversary of his death.[5]
- **Titles:** Bishop of Alexandria, Confessor and Doctor of the Church.[6] He earned the name "Father of Orthodoxy."[7]

✠ His Life in Brief

Athanasius began as a deacon and secretary to Bishop Alexander of Alexandria, and as a young cleric he went with his bishop to the Council of Nicaea in 325.[8] [9] There the bishops answered the priest Arius, who taught that the Logos "was not a true God but a created God."[10] When Alexander died, Athanasius was chosen to succeed him.[11]

- He refused to readmit Arius to communion when the emperor asked, because there could be no fellowship between the Church and the one who denied the divinity of Christ.[12]

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2. "St. Athanasius," in *The Catholic Encyclopedia*, vol. 2 (New York: Robert Appleton Company, 1907).
3. Ibid.
4. Ibid.
5. Ibid.
6. Ibid.
7. Ibid.
8. Benedict XVI, "Saint Athanasius of Alexandria," General Audience, June 20, 2007.
9. "St. Athanasius," *Catholic Encyclopedia*.
10. Benedict XVI, "Saint Athanasius."
11. "St. Athanasius," *Catholic Encyclopedia*.
12. Ibid.

- He was exiled again and again. In the thirty years between 336 and 366 he left his city at least five times and spent 17 years in exile.[13]
- In exile he sustained the Nicene faith in the West and spread the monastic ideals of the hermit Anthony.[14] He also wrote the *Life of Anthony*.[15]
- He wrote that the Word "was made man that we might be made God,"[16] a line Benedict XVI said has rightly become famous.[17]
- He died in his own bed, not by violence or in hiding, after all that.[18]

✠ Famous Excerpt: *On the Incarnation* 54

> *"For He was made man that we might be made God; and He manifested Himself by a body that we might receive the idea of the unseen Father; and He endured the insolence of men that we might inherit immortality."*[19]

✠ 1. Catechesis

Lesson: the Creed we pray at Sunday Mass. The Creed began at Nicaea, where the bishops answered Arius.[20] Athanasius defended its key word, *homoousios*, as the sense in which the Church had

13. Benedict XVI, "Saint Athanasius."
14. Ibid.
15. Ibid.
16. Athanasius, *On the Incarnation of the Word*, ch. 54, sec. 3, trans. Archibald Robertson, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, vol. 4 (Buffalo: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1892).
17. Benedict XVI, "Saint Athanasius."
18. "St. Athanasius," *Catholic Encyclopedia*.
19. Athanasius, *On the Incarnation* 54.3.
20. Benedict XVI, "Saint Athanasius."

always held Jesus Christ to be the Son of God.[21] Late in life he wrote, "Let what was confessed by the Fathers of Nicaea prevail."[22]

Exercise: have students read the second paragraph of the Nicene Creed aloud and mark each phrase that says Jesus is truly God.

✠ 2. Apologetics

Objection 1: "The divinity of Christ was invented at Nicaea, under Constantine." The council met because the emperor wanted to end the scandalous debates that Arius had started.[23] Nicaea answered Arius's claim that the Logos was a created god,[24] and the council's key word expressed the sense in which the Church had always held Jesus Christ to be the Son of God.[25] Athanasius had already written about the Word becoming man around 318, before Arianism had begun to make itself felt.[26]

Objection 2: "It was only a quarrel about a word, so it did not matter." Athanasius answered that it mattered because of what Christ does for us: the Word "was made man that we might be made God."[27] If the Word were only a creature, the creature could not bring us to God. This is why he would not compromise with the Arian party.[28]

21. "St. Athanasius," *Catholic Encyclopedia*.
22. Ibid.
23. Ibid.
24. Benedict XVI, "Saint Athanasius."
25. "St. Athanasius," *Catholic Encyclopedia*.
26. Ibid.
27. Athanasius, *On the Incarnation* 54.3.
28. "St. Athanasius," *Catholic Encyclopedia*.

✠ 3. Theology

- **Homoousios:** the Son is of one substance with the Father, and not a creature "halfway" between God and man.[29]
- **The Incarnation:** the Word, impassible and incorruptible, took a body for our sake and endured human insolence so that we might inherit immortality.[30]
- **Deification:** the Word "was made man that we might be made God," a line Benedict XVI said has rightly become famous.[31]

✠ 4. Devotional Prayer

Collect, Memorial of St. Athanasius (Roman Missal, May 2):[32]
Almighty ever-living God, who raised up the Bishop Saint Athanasius as an outstanding champion of your Son's divinity, mercifully grant, that, rejoicing in his teaching and his protection, we may never cease to grow in knowledge and love of you.

Practice: Pray the Nicene Creed slowly today, pausing on "true God from true God," and offer it for someone who doubts that Jesus is God.

✠ Today's Takeaway

Athanasius held to the truth that Christ is God when it cost him his city, and the Church still prays his words in the Creed.[33]

St. Athanasius, pray for us.

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29. Benedict XVI, "Saint Athanasius."
30. Athanasius, *On the Incarnation* 54.3.
31. Benedict XVI, "Saint Athanasius."
32. *The Roman Missal*, 3rd typical ed. (2011), May 2, Memorial of St. Athanasius, Collect.
33. "St. Athanasius," *Catholic Encyclopedia*.